

LW5600: LAW SCHOOL SURVIVAL SKILLS WORKSHOP

Effective Term

Semester A 2026/27

Part I Course Overview

Course Title

Law School Survival Skills Workshop

Subject Code

LW - Law

Course Number

5600

Academic Unit

School of Law (FL)

College/School

School of Law (FL)

Course Duration

One Semester

Credit Units

1.5

Level

P5, P6 - Postgraduate Degree

Medium of Instruction

English

Medium of Assessment

English

Prerequisites

Nil

Precursors

Nil

Equivalent Courses

Nil

Exclusive Courses

Nil

Part II Course Details

Abstract

This intensive preparatory course introduces students to the basic skills that are necessary to succeed in legal education and introduces them to the legal profession. The course offers an overview of the Hong Kong legal system and common law legal sources to help students to prepare for their first semester courses. This course will give students a foundation in how to read caselaw, statutes, and other legal materials and in using standard patterns of legal writing and methods of legal analysis that will be developed further in the first-year Legal Methods, Research and Writing (LW5622). The course focuses on helping students prepare for success in lecture, tutorials, assignments, and examinations. Individual and team-based learning will be utilized on a pass-fail basis. It is essential for all students starting legal education to attend this course.

Course Intended Learning Outcomes (CILOs)

CILOs		Weighting (if app.)	DEC-A1	DEC-A2	DEC-A3
1	Develop the ability to identify and discuss the common patterns and forms used in caselaw and statutory materials within the Hong Kong commonwealth legal system	20	x	x	
2	Develop basic analytical skills for legal reading and writing	20	x	x	
3	Engage in critical analysis and develop problem-solving skills using primary and secondary legal authorities and analysing how they ground legal argument	10	x	x	
4	Develop strategies for lecture and tutorial preparation, continuous assessments, and examinations	20	x	x	x
5	Engage with practitioners in different areas of legal practice and explore professionalism expectations and career paths	30	x		

A1: Attitude

Develop an attitude of discovery/innovation/creativity, as demonstrated by students possessing a strong sense of curiosity, asking questions actively, challenging assumptions or engaging in inquiry together with teachers.

A2: Ability

Develop the ability/skill needed to discover/innovate/create, as demonstrated by students possessing critical thinking skills to assess ideas, acquiring research skills, synthesizing knowledge across disciplines or applying academic knowledge to real-life problems.

A3: Accomplishments

Demonstrate accomplishment of discovery/innovation/creativity through producing /constructing creative works/new artefacts, effective solutions to real-life problems or new processes.

Learning and Teaching Activities (LTAs)

LTAs	Brief Description	CILO No.	Hours/week (if applicable)
1	Lecture · Students will engage with the basic sources of law in the common law legal system; · Students will gain exposure to the core expectations and foundational skills required in first-year courses · Students will encounter course preparation best practices from upper-level peers.	1, 2, 3, 4	6
2	Exercises and Group Discussions · Students will discuss and analyse practical problems and possible solutions with their peers; · Students will practice oral, analytical, and team-based skills in group exercises; · Students will practice evaluating, critically analysing, and working with legal sources together. · Through group exercises, students will develop an attitude of curiosity and, critical thinking.	1, 2, 3, 4	4
3	Readings	Students will engage with daily readings in preparation for class.	1, 2, 3, 4 3
4	Assignments	· Students will engage in-class exercises to solidify prior knowledge or explore new topics for the following class session · Students will critically assess each other's work and receive peer feedback on select assignments. · Students will evaluate the utility and limitations of GenAI tools for generating answers to legal problems.	1, 2, 3, 4 3

5	Career Foundations Seminars	· Students will explore career paths and deepen their understanding of professionalism skills by engaging with legal professionals in a seminar setting and preparing written responses.	5	6
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Assessment Tasks / Activities (ATs)

	ATs	CILO No.	Weighting (%)	Remarks	Allow Use of GenAI?
1	Class Participation	1, 2, 3, 4, 5	30	-	No
2	Class Assignments (Individual or Group)	1, 2, 3, 4, 5	70	-	No

Continuous Assessment (%)

100

Additional Information for ATs

This course is marked on a pass-fail basis and there is no course examination. Participation and class assignments will be marked on a pass-fail basis. To pass this course, students must pass both components. Due to the intensive nature of this course, unexcused absences of more than three (3) classroom hours and failing to complete all 6 hours of required professional seminar training will result in a failing mark for the participation component and thus for the course. Students must complete all 6 hours of professional seminar hours required.

Assessment Rubrics (AR)**Assessment Task**

Class Participation

Criterion

Attends daily. Actively participates in in-class activities and exercises. Actively contributes to team-based exercises and in-class discussions.

Pass (P)

(P) Adequate

Failure (F)

(F) Inadequate

Assessment Task

Class Assignments

Criterion

Timely completes all assignments in accordance with instructions at a level that demonstrates appropriate effort and attention to detail in written work product.

Pass (P)

(P) Adequate

Failure (F)

(F) Inadequate

Part III Other Information

Keyword Syllabus

Common law sources of law, caselaw, statutes, legal reasoning, legal interpretation, binding precedent, case analysis, legal reading, legal writing, legal profession, coursework skills, task management, team-based learning

Detailed Course Programme

A detailed course programme will be provided in advance of the first class session as part of the Course Manual. The major topics covered in the course include, but are not limited to, the following:

- Introduction to the Hong Kong commonwealth system
- Reading skills for different purposes
- Introduction to legal writing forms and conventions
- Introduction to legal authority and precedent
- Reading case law
- Reading statutory law
- Using primary sources of authority
- Using secondary sources of authority
- Integrating statutory and case law sources
- Legal problem-solving skills
- Professionalism skills
- Working in teams; Group problem-solving
- Preparing for lectures, tutorials, and continuous assessments
- Preparing for exams
- Introduction to the legal profession

Reading List**Compulsory Readings**

Title	
1	The following course text is required: James Holland & Julian Webb, <i>Learning Legal Rules</i> (11th ed. OUP 2022). Note that this text will also be required in the first-semester legal research and writing course.
2	Additional compulsory readings will be distributed to students in advance of each class session. Where appropriate, copies of readings will be made available to the students either through the library catalogue, internet links, or by lodging materials with the library's semi-closed collection.
3	No external legal research is required for this course. However, students are encouraged to explore the law library and its print and electronic resources. These are available at:
4	https://www.cityu.edu.hk/lib/collect/law/index.htm
5	https://libguides.library.cityu.edu.hk/home (click subject = law)

Additional Readings

Title	
1	Optional reading materials will be made available to students through a variety of ways. Where appropriate, copies of readings will be made available to the students either through the library catalogue, internet links, or by lodging materials with the library's semi-closed collection. The following may be taken as examples of indicative reading:
2	Bradney A., Cownie, F., Masson, J., Neal A. & Newell, D. <i>How to Study Law</i> (8th ed. London, Sweet & Maxwell, 2017)

3	Bergman, Paul, Patrick Goodman, Thomas Holm, Cracking the Case Method, Legal Analysis for Law School Success (West 2022)
4	Charrow, Veda R., Myra K. Erhardt & Robert P. Charrow Clear and Effective Legal Writing (5th ed. Aspen, 2013)
5	Finch, Emily & Stefan Fafinski, Legal Skills (OUP 2021) or (OUP 2025) (Highly recommended!)
6	Neumann Jr, Richard K, Legal Reasoning and Legal Writing: Structure, Strategy, and Style (6th ed, New York: Wolters Kluwer Law & Business 6th ed. 2009)
7	Mitchell, Jay, Picturing Corporate Practice (West, 2016)
8	Smith, A.T.H., Glanville Williams: Learning the Law (17th ed, London: Sweet and Maxwell, 2020)
9	Ip, Eric, Law & Justice in Hong Kong (Sweet & Maxwell, 4th ed. 2022)